West well, while diminishing its competitors. The mix of institutions, regimes, regulations and understandings is such a complex web that creating alternatives is truly a formidable challenge. However, as global power redistribution progresses, this will inevitably happen.

If the entrenched have to compromise with the emerging, the issue is not of the extent and nature alone. More important, it is with whom all it should do so. With China, the Western logic of engagement has been primarily that of mutual economic gain. If there are stresses today, that is because its mutuality has come under some questioning. But India is a different case, because there is also a political overlay to the economic logic. Its pluralistic character and democratic outlook is closer to that of the West. India's economic growth and political stature, as a result, is today imbued with a larger significance. Contributing to its rise can be part of shaping the new global strategic balance. India too would do well to recall that in history, some nations have been partnered by others reflecting a larger calculus.

It is not just India's capabilities but also the relative weight of the West that is changing. If the US specifically and the West as a whole has lost its edge, that is due to its miscalculations on political Islam and China respectively. Added to that are problems emanating from economic, social, demographic and political trends that have been long in the making. Social trends have also been driving greater nationalism and insularity in the West. Immigration, when combined with policies promoting income disparity, has fuelled an anti-globalization narrative. As cultural nationalism spiked, the West also turned on itself: the UK on Europe and the US on its alliance commitments.

Where Europe is concerned, there has anyway been a sustained global retrenchment following the Eurozone crisis. In large measure, Europe withdrew politically from Asia, defining its interests primarily in economic terms. But the pace of change in the last decade has been so sharp that it soon found itself on the defensive even on its home turf. The comfort that the Atlantic alliance long provided has also now come into question. So, we have a picture of some turmoil and disarray. Gaps between the US and Europe are apparent on many issues even as Europe itself stands divided after years of promoting internal unity. Indeed, matters have reached a state